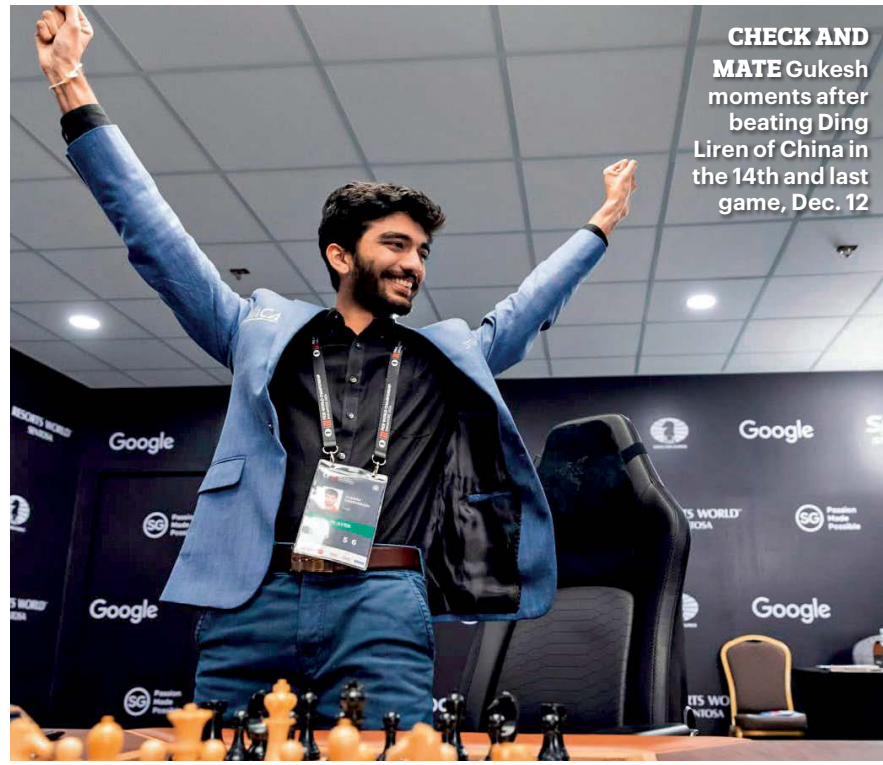




CHECK AND MATE Gukesh moments after beating Ding Liren of China in the 14th and last game, Dec. 12

THE GOLDEN GENERATION COMES OF AGE

› **April 2024** Gukesh D., 17, wins the Candidates tournament, becomes youngest World Championship challenger

› **June** Divya Deshmukh, 18, wins the World Junior Girls title, moves into Top 20 in women's ranking

› **September** Double gold at the Chess Olympiad, men's and women's team win. Gukesh, Arjun Erigaisi, Vantika Agrawal and Deshmukh win individual golds

› **November** All of 3 years, Anish Sarkar becomes the world's youngest rated player; Elo* rating: 1555

› **December** Arjun Erigaisi is only the second Indian after V. Anand to cross 2800 in Elo rating

Gukesh beats Ding Liren to be crowned World Champion at 18, the youngest ever to win the title

**named after its creator Arpad Elo, it's a method for calculating relative skill levels of players*

THE KIDS ARE ALRIGHT

India's groundbreaking year in chess isn't over yet as Erigaisi, Praggnanandhaa, Raunak Sadhwani (19), Aravindh Chithambaram (25) and Pranav V. (18) are among 10 Indians competing in the ongoing World Rapid and Blitz Championship in New York (December 26-30). Also in the Big Apple are the rising queens of the chessboard: R. Vaishali (23), who was tied second at the Candidates; Divya Deshmukh (19), the reigning junior girls champion; and women's International Master (IM) Vantika Agrawal (22). The trio was also part of the women's team which won gold at the Chess Olympiad in Budapest.

Kasparov has described it as "an Indian earthquake in chess". For India now has 85 GMs, over half of them coming after Anand's world championship triumphs. Currently, an estimated 200 Indians are professional chess players. Hear Generation Next talk of chess and one gets a sense that this is less about success and big money and more about mad love and respect for the game. "One move just changes the whole position and result," says Pragg. "It's what keeps me excited about looking at games and learning new things." In elder sister Vaishali, the 2023 World Cup finalist is lucky to have someone at home with whom he can discuss all things chess. The duo is world's first brother-sister grandmaster pair. "You have these opening